

Inline vs Block Elements in HTML/CSS

Block Elements

- **Behavior:** Take up the full width available, start on a new line
- **Dimensions:** Can have width/height set
- **Spacing:** Create line breaks before and after
- **Default:** `display: block`
- **Examples:**

```
html
```

```
<div>, <p>, <h1>-<h6>, <section>, <ul>, <li>
```

- **Use case:** For major layout sections, paragraphs, lists

Inline Elements

- **Behavior:** Flow within text/content, don't start new lines
- **Dimensions:** Width/height determined by content, can't be set
- **Spacing:** Sit next to other inline elements
- **Default:** `display: inline`
- **Examples:**

```
html
```

```
<span>, <a>, <strong>, <em>, <img>, <button>
```

- **Use case:** For styling parts of text, links, inline icons

Key Differences

```
CSS
```

```
/* Block element */
div {
  width: 100%; /* Can set width */
  height: 200px; /* Can set height */
  margin: 10px; /* Vertical margins respected */
}

/* Inline element */
span {
  width: 100px; /* Ignored */
  height: 100px; /* Ignored */
  margin-top: 20px; /* Ignored vertically */
}
```

Inline-Block Hybrid

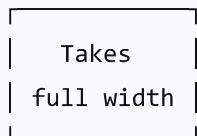
CSS

```
/* Gets best of both */
.inline-block {
  display: inline-block;
  width: 150px; /* Can set */
  height: 150px; /* Can set */
  /* But sits inline like text */
}
```

Visual Comparison

text

Block:



Inline:

Text with an inline
element | Like | that flows
this | in sentence

Next block
starts below ▼



Quick Rules

1. **Block:** Layout structure, sections, containers
2. **Inline:** Text-level semantics, styling words/phrases
3. **Never put block elements inside inline elements** (invalid HTML)
4. **Inline elements ignore vertical margins/padding**
5. **Use** `inline-block` when you need inline flow with box model control